STIVEN CATALYST

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MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.



AI

ALGORITHMIC MANAGEMENT OF WORK

The EU's first rules on algorithmic management and their deadline, how many workers software already directs, instructing, monitoring and evaluating, what managers worry about, four counts and a card for one automated decision.

27% of workers in the EU say the organisation they work for uses digital technologies to allocate tasks, working time or shifts to them automatically.

EU-OSHA, 2025

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A roster drawn up by software, a task pushed to a phone, a score that ranks the team: algorithms now do parts of a manager's work. How far has that gone, what does the EU's first law on it require, and what must a manager still answer for? These pages describe the law; they are not legal advice.

Directive (EU) 2024/2831 sets the EU's first rules on algorithmic management, for digital labour platforms, and must be transposed by 2 December 2026. Yet only 5% of EU workers earned income through a platform in the year to spring 2025, while about one in four say software allocates their tasks or shifts, and nearly as many that it instructs, rates or monitors them. In an OECD survey of over 6,000 managers, 60% of users say the tools improve their decisions, and nearly two-thirds have at least one concern. A Swedish study links heavy algorithmic management in logistics with more distress and accidents.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

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HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure
Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

Our reading
Where the editors interpret rather than the research, it says so.

Practice
The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

COVER STORY

Rules for the algorithmic boss

Chapter III of Directive (EU) 2024/2831 on platform work, adopted in October 2024, holds the EU's first rules on algorithmic management, and most of them also cover the self-employed. Member States must transpose it “by 2 December 2026”.

01

What it may not process

Emotional state, private conversations, data from outside working time (Art. 7).

02

Who is told what

Which systems monitor or decide, on what data, by the first working day (Art. 9).

03

A human oversees

An evaluation at least every two years; a human suspends or closes an account (Art. 10).

04

A right to an answer

An explanation, and a reply to a request for review within two weeks (Art. 11).

For other workplaces nothing is settled yet. In December 2025 the European Parliament asked for such rules in all of them; in July 2026 the Commission included algorithmic management in its consultation on a Quality Jobs Act.

OUR READING

The directive is written for platforms, but its four questions fit any team where software hands out shifts or scores.

Sources: European Parliament and Council of the European Union, Official Journal L, 11 November 2024, 2024; European Parliament, 2025; European Commission, Employment, Social Affairs and Inclusion, 2026

Articles 7, 9–11 and 29, shortened; national laws will word them in their own way. The Parliament's request is not law. This is a description, not legal advice.

THE NUMBERS

A quarter, not a niche

In spring 2025, EU-OSHA's OSH Pulse asked 25,688 workers in the EU by telephone whether the organisation they work for uses digital technologies to manage parts of their work.

WORKERS IN THE EU, 2025



The JRC's AIM-WORK survey of 70,316 people in late 2024 and early 2025 asked more narrowly about systems acting with little or no human input: 24% of workers had their rosters or shift hours allocated automatically, 21% their tasks.

OUR READING

The directive reaches the 5%. The practices it regulates reach about a quarter of all workers.

Sources: EU-OSHA, 2025; Ignacio González Vázquez, Enrique Fernández-Macías, Sally Wright & Davide Villani, European Commission, Joint Research Centre, 2025

Self-reports, EU-27. OSH Pulse asks what workers know of their organisation; 2–3% did not know. Platform income, over the past 12 months, is a separate question. The two surveys ask in different ways, so their figures differ.

THE MODEL

Instruct, monitor, evaluate

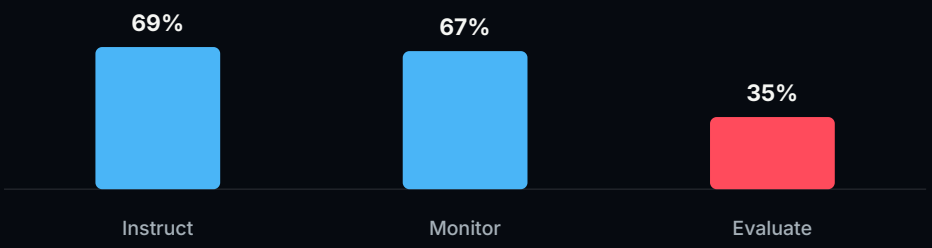
The OECD defines algorithmic management as software, with or without AI, that fully or partly automates tasks done by human managers.

01
Instruct
schedules, activities, clients, task instructions

02
Monitor
time, speed, location, tone of calls, fatigue

03
Evaluate
targets, rewards, sanctions, leaderboards

FIRMS USING EACH GROUP, AVERAGE OF FRANCE, GERMANY, ITALY AND SPAIN



In the US, adoption averages 90% across all three groups; in Japan, 40% of firms use any tool at all. Everywhere, tools that sanction are rarer than those that reward: 14% against 23%.

OUR READING

The further a tool reaches into personal data or into consequences, the rarer it is, and the more a manager's judgement counts.

Sources: Anna Milanez, Annikka Lemmens & Carla Ruggiu, OECD Artificial Intelligence Papers No. 31, 2025; OECD, policy brief, 2025

Over 6,000 mid-level managers in six countries answered for their firms, on fifteen uses in three groups. The OECD calls its definition broad: in the four European countries 79% use at least one tool. Not every tool uses AI, so the AI Act (No. 41) covers only some of them.

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Better decisions, unclear accountability

In the OECD survey, 60% of managers using the tools said their decisions had improved, thanks to more information, speed and autonomy. Yet nearly two-thirds had at least one concern.

MANAGERS USING THE TOOLS WHO REPORT THE CONCERN, SIX COUNTRIES



For workers the evidence is thin. In a 2024 survey of nearly 1,000 drivers and warehouse workers in Sweden, the most exposed reported psychological distress about twice as often as the least exposed (ratio 2.12), and accidents 1.9 times as often. The JRC finds clearly worse conditions for the 2% of EU workers subject to every form at once.

OUR READING

The most common worry lies behind the software: when a decision is wrong, nobody is sure who answers for it.

Sources: OECD, policy brief, 2025; K. Hennum Nilsson, T. Bodin, P. Strauss et al., International Archives of Occupational and Environmental Health 98, 2025; Ignacio González Vázquez, Enrique Fernández-Macías, Sally Wright & Davide Villani, European Commission, Joint Research Centre, 2025

Self-reports. The Swedish study is a one-time survey, recruited partly online: it shows a link, not a cause. Across all EU workers the JRC's links are mild, and they do not prove a cause either.

HOW IT IS MEASURED

Four counts for one system

The directive's yardsticks can serve any team as measures, platform or not. The survey question works as a test too: ask the team what the system does, and compare their answers with what it really does.

1. **Informed**
   Share of the team who can say what the system decides and on what data. A "don't know" is a finding.

2. **Explained**
   Requests for an explanation or review answered within two weeks, the directive's limit for a review.

3. **Decided by a person**
   Sanctions, suspensions or pay changes a human checked before they applied.

4. **Evaluated**
   Date of the last review of the system's effect on the team, at least every two years.

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, A SHIFT-PLANNING SYSTEM IN A TEAM OF 30

Informed	12 of 30 could say what it decides
Explained	5 requests, 3 answered within two weeks
Evaluated	never in three years

The system may work well, but the team has no way to know. The figures are made up.

Sources: European Parliament and Council of the European Union, Official Journal L, 11 November 2024, 2024; EU-OSHA, 2025

The counts are the editors' reading of Articles 9–11 of the directive and of the OSH Pulse question. Its limits bind platforms; for other employers they serve as a benchmark.

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

One automated decision card

One card for each decision that software takes or prepares. Fill it in with the people it affects; where a line stays empty, the gap is the finding.

01 The decision what it decides or proposes: shifts, tasks, targets, a rating, a sanction

02 Data what it uses, and what it must not: feelings, private talk, time off work

03 Who can review it the role that can check and override it, and how fast

04 How the team learns of it when they were told, in what words, where it is written

05 Explanation and challenge who answers, and within how many days

06 Last evaluation date, who took part, what changed

Sources: European Parliament and Council of the European Union, Official Journal L, 11 November 2024, 2024; OECD, policy brief, 2025

A practice the editors propose, drawing on Articles 7–11 of the directive and the concerns in the OECD survey. When a decision proves wrong, the 5 Whys sheet helps you trace why and name one owner.

Open the tool: 5 Whys stivencatalyst.com/tools/five-whys/

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

Directive (EU) 2024/2831 on improving working conditions in platform work
European Parliament and Council of the European Union, Official Journal L, 11 November 2024, 2024
https://eur-lex.europa.eu/eli/dir/2024/2831/oj/eng

Recommendations to the Commission on digitalisation, artificial intelligence and algorithmic management in the workplace (2025/2080(INL))
European Parliament, 2025
https://www.europarl.europa.eu/doceo/document/TA-10-2025-0337_EN.html

Commission opens second-phase consultation on Quality Jobs Act
European Commission, Employment, Social Affairs and Inclusion, 2026
https://employment-social-affairs.ec.europa.eu/news/commission-opens-second-phase-consultation-quality-jobs-act-2026-07-20_en

OSH Pulse 2025: Occupational safety and health in the era of climate and digital change
EU-OSHA, 2025
https://osha.europa.eu/en/publications/osh-pulse-2025-occupational-safety-and-health-era-climate-and-digital-change

Digital Monitoring, Algorithmic Management and the Platformisation of Work in Europe
Ignacio González Vázquez, Enrique Fernández-Macías, Sally Wright & Davide Villani, European Commission, Joint Research Centre, 2025
https://doi.org/10.2760/9406086

Algorithmic management in the workplace: New evidence from an OECD employer survey
Anna Milanez, Annikka Lemmens & Carla Ruggiu, OECD Artificial Intelligence Papers No. 31, 2025
https://doi.org/10.1787/287c13c4-en

How widespread is algorithmic management in workplaces?
OECD, policy brief, 2025
https://www.oecd.org/content/dam/oecd/en/publications/reports/2025/12/how-widespread-is-algorithmic-management-in-workplaces_d1e62812/cda7a114-en.pdf

Algorithmic management is associated with psychological distress, musculoskeletal pain, and occupational accidents: a cross-sectional study in logistics
K. Hennum Nilsson, T. Bodin, P. Strauss et al., International Archives of Occupational and Environmental Health 98, 2025
https://doi.org/10.1007/s00420-025-02180-5

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what exactly it measures. Where the publisher's page could not be opened, the figure was checked against independent summaries and is marked “via”. The editors' interpretation is marked “Our reading”. Figures that could not be confirmed are not in the issue.



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

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Every issue, one management question, checked against the best research.

ALL ISSUES

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